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ALTHOUGH THE ELDAMS ROAD OPERATION TURNED OUT TO BE A smokescreen,

Verma instinctively knew that this was the thread the SIT needed to follow to track Sivarasan. He and Ragothaman met the engineer's wife again. They learnt about an elderly Sri Lankan lady, 'Aunty', who was instrumental in Raja's visit to her apartment to meet Dixon. Apparently, she lived with her daughter in Royapettah, Madras. The officers' next destination was Aunty's house. When brought to Malligai for questioning sometime in July, the SIT realized the importance of the lady in the investigation. Aunty claimed that 'Thambi Anna' had brought Sivarasan to her house in the first week of May. He carried an introductory letter from her mother, who lived in Valvettithurai in Jaffna—a place where the LTTE's armed struggle had taken birth under Prabhakaran. Apparently, Aunty's mother had asked her to extend whatever help was necessary to Sivarasan.[1]

Sivarasan had become a regular visitor to Aunty's house. He particularly enjoyed her sour fish curry with rice. One day he brought a young girl, 'Gowri', and asked Aunty if she could keep her for a week. Aunty was planning to go on a tour of south India with her family. She was sceptical about Gowri staying alone at the house. Sivarasan assured her that Gowri was smart and could look after the place. After Aunty left, Sivarasan brought over more guests. First, it was Raja and then Kanagasabapathy. Gowri gave her real name to the old man. She was Athirai, and part of the hit squad of the LTTE. This was the first time Kanagasabapathy and Athirai had met. It was planned for him to take her to Delhi. But with Thambi Anna, another LTTE operative close to Sivarasan, getting picked up by the Q branch of the police, Sivarasan did not think it was safe to keep Athirai there any more.